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BY ALL INDICATIONS Gen Z is a disruptive audience for whom each experience must be unique and devoid of any inhibitions; they push the marketer to the limits of innovation. That's one of the central findings of the *B/T-PRICE* Gen Z Consumption Behaviour Survey, too. Given their size in terms of actual numbers and the ability to spend, most companies have a robust Gen Z strategy.

This is not the first time consumer research has thrown up an insight that leads to the birth of an idea. Fevicol ShoeFix is a case in point. A close look at NCCS A homes—a housing classification used by the National Consumer Classification System (NCCS), which is widely used in India for market research, media planning, and audience segmentation—revealed that the average Gen Z consumer had 10-12 pairs of sneakers. Given the high disposable incomes, that was not a surprise.

In fact, the sneakers worn were determined by the occasion. “It could be for badminton, cricket, party or just hanging out with friends,” says Sandeep Tanwani, CMO, Pidilite Industries, the entity that owns Fevicol, Dr Fixit, M-Seal, Araldite and Roff brands, among others.

“There is a flaunting value in sneakers, which have a high emotional value as well,” he says. This led to the launch of Fevicol ShoeFix, an adhesive specially designed for DIY shoe repair. Obviously, a new approach is needed for a new generation.

To him, the Gen Z audience comes with a lot of spending power. “They define cultural trends, and a big difference compared to other cohorts is how they want to spend for an experience,” says Tanwani, who confesses to having seen some Gen Z folks owning 50 pairs of sneakers.

CRACKING THE CONSUMER

The Gen Z cohort exists across the world, but India, as always, is writing its own story. The heterogeneity of our population, a high proportion of youth and technology bridging every conceivable divide across regions make the opportunity quite irresistible.

“It is important to understand that within Gen Z, there are multiple cohorts just with respect to age,” says Anand Kumar Jaiswal, Professor of Marketing at the

Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Ahmedabad.

A lot of time has gone into analysing how Gen Z is different, and he identifies a combination of “information capital and digital skill” to describe them. “The power of economic capital in the past lay with the parents. Now, information moving away is a marked change.”

For instance, it is obviously a digital-native cohort. “They have never seen an offline world, and with information, they influence purchase decisions in both traditional and high-value product categories. It includes fashion, personal products, food and automobiles,” says Jaiswal.

One must look to artificial intelligence (AI) to grasp that point. To him, it is not used just as an information tool, but to make comparisons, sift through multiple sources of information, and come up with detailed information that is incisive and stands out. “Look at a category like cosmetics, where the conversation is now around chemicals and ingredient sources. That is understood well by parents, making them also well-informed,” he adds.

The large companies are acutely aware of that. At the second quarter earnings call for FY26, Hindustan Unilever's (HUL's) CEO & MD, Priya Nair, spent time outlining how her company, the big boy of the fast-moving consumer goods industry, will

There are almost 400 million Gen Z consumers in India, and they are driving change and transformation. Companies are reimagining brands as more modern and youthful